Experiment 13

Case Study on Limitations of Low-Code Platforms for a Complex Enterprise Use Case

Aim

To study the limitations of low-code platforms when they are applied to complex enterprise-level applications and to understand when pro-code extensions or hybrid approaches may become necessary.

Introduction

Low-code platforms allow applications to be developed mainly through visual development tools instead of writing large amounts of traditional program code. Applications are assembled using predefined components such as forms, reports and dashboards, and behaviour is defined through workflows, rules and configuration. A small amount of scripting is usually available for specific needs. This approach reduces development time and effort and makes it possible for a wider range of people to take part in building business applications.

Low-code platforms are well suited to standard business applications. As the requirements of an enterprise grow in terms of users, data volume, process complexity, integrations, security and customisation, the built-in capabilities of a platform may no longer be sufficient on their own. This case study examines such limitations through an enterprise gym membership scenario.

Case Study: Enterprise Gym Membership Management System

A fitness organisation with many branches requires a system to manage its gym operations. The system may need to serve the following users and handle the following functions:

Category	Items
Users	Members, front-desk staff, trainers, branch managers and administrators
Data and operations	Member records, membership plans, class and trainer scheduling, attendance and membership history
Supporting functions	Notifications, payments and equipment inventory
Enterprise integration and insight	CRM integration, access-control integration, analytics and reporting

The architecture of this system on a low-code platform is arranged as six groups that are connected from left to right:

- **Users:** members, front-desk staff, trainers, branch managers and administrators, who interact with the system.
- **Gym Membership Application:** the user-facing part, covering membership registration, member details, plan details, class scheduling and membership status.
- **Business Logic & Workflow:** registration processing, approval workflow, notifications, trainer assignment and status updates, which move a membership request through the process.
- **Data Management:** the member database, plan records, attendance history and membership requests, in which the information is stored.
- **External Enterprise Systems:** the payment system, CRM, equipment inventory system, access-control system and email / SMS notification services with which the application must exchange information.

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- **Analytics & Reporting:** membership performance, member reports, operational KPIs and a management dashboard, which present the stored and processed data to decision makers.

The groups interact in sequence. Users enter and view information through the application; the business logic and workflow layer processes this information; the data layer stores and supplies it; external systems provide or receive related information such as payments, customer relationships and equipment inventory; and the analytics layer reports on the results.

How a Low-Code Platform Can Support the System

A large part of the system consists of standard application functionality that low-code platforms are designed to handle:

Capability	Use in the Gym Membership System
Forms	Capturing membership registrations, member details and plan details.
Reports	Viewing memberships, attendance history and member reports.
Workflows	Moving a membership request through processing, approval, trainer assignment and status updates.
Business process automation	Applying rules and automatic actions, such as updating a status when a payment is completed.
Data management	Storing member, plan and attendance records and performing standard create, read, update and delete operations.
User interfaces	Providing web and mobile screens for members, staff, trainers, managers and administrators.
Notifications	Informing members about renewal and status updates through email or similar messages.
Basic integrations	Connecting to common services through built-in connectors or standard interfaces.

Limitations at Enterprise Scale

As the system grows into a complex enterprise application, the following limitations may become significant. They are discussed individually below.

Performance and Scalability

When the number of members, attendance records and users becomes very large, performance may be affected. Complex queries and reports over large amounts of data can respond slowly, and the platform may impose limits on how far an application can be scaled. Because the underlying infrastructure is managed by the platform, the options for tuning performance are limited.

Complex Business Logic

Highly specialised business rules, such as intricate membership pricing and offer rules, trainer and class scheduling optimisation across branches, and advanced processing, may be difficult to express using visual workflows and standard scripting. Such requirements may need custom development.

System Integration

Connecting the application to ERP and CRM systems, payment gateways, access-control hardware, legacy systems, external APIs and other enterprise services can be challenging. Built-in connectors may not cover every system or data format, and complex or real-time integrations may need custom interfaces.

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Customization

Standard low-code components provide common screens and layouts. Highly specialised interfaces and user experiences, or functionality that is not offered by the platform, may exceed what these standard components can provide.

Security and Governance

Enterprises require detailed access control, governance, compliance and strong security practices. Role- and permission-based controls offered by a platform may need to be supplemented to meet fine-grained, regulatory or organisation-specific requirements, and governance of many applications must be managed carefully.

AI and Advanced Technology

Specialised artificial intelligence and machine-learning models, such as predicting membership churn, and other advanced processing may require external services or custom code, since a low-code platform may not provide such capabilities directly.

Vendor / Platform Dependency

The application depends on the capabilities, restrictions, pricing and supported integrations of the selected platform. Features may be limited by the plan or edition, and moving an application to another platform later can be difficult.

Data Management

Large datasets, complex relationships between records and advanced data processing, such as heavy batch processing or complex data transformations, may be difficult to handle within the data model and tools provided by the platform.

In summary, a basic low-code application, characterised by quick development, minimal configuration and suitability for small and medium needs, faces growing enterprise requirements: more users and data, complex business processes, integration with multiple systems and higher security and compliance needs. These lead to enterprise-scale challenges such as increased complexity, higher performance demands, greater integration needs, stronger security and governance, and more customisation and flexibility. The eight limitations above are the key ones that result.

The relevance of each limitation to the Enterprise Gym Membership Management System is given below.

Limitation	Relevance to the Case Study
Performance & Scalability	Growing numbers of members, branches and attendance records, and reports over membership history.
Complex Business Logic	Approval workflows, trainer assignment and class scheduling rules that become more complex over time.
System Integration	Payment system, CRM, equipment inventory, access-control system and email / SMS services.
Customization	Specialised interfaces for trainers, front-desk staff and managers, and a tailored member experience.
Security & Governance	Different access needs for members, staff, trainers, managers and administrators; protection of member and payment-related data.
AI / Advanced Technology	Possible intelligent features built on attendance history and operational data, such as churn prediction.
Vendor Dependency	Reliance on the platform for all application, workflow and reporting features, and on its plan limits.

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Limitation	Relevance to the Case Study
Data Management	Large volumes of member records and attendance history with relationships to plans, payments and trainers.

Low-Code vs Pro-Code Requirements

The suitability of low-code or pro-code development depends on the requirements of the application. Neither approach is universally better; the comparison below indicates the typical role of each.

Area	Low-Code Approach	When Pro-Code May Be Required
User interface	Standard screens, forms and layouts built from predefined components.	Highly specialised interfaces or custom user experiences beyond standard components.
Business logic	Visual workflows, rules and simple scripting for common business processes.	Complex rules and advanced processing that cannot be expressed in visual tools.
Data management	Built-in data model with forms, relationships and standard create, read, update and delete operations.	Very large datasets, complex relationships and advanced data processing.
Integrations	Built-in connectors and standard interfaces for common services.	Legacy systems, specialised or real-time integrations and systems without connectors.
Automation	Rules, scheduled actions and workflow-based automation.	Complex or high-volume automation and specialised processing.
AI/ML	Basic features offered by the platform, where available.	Custom AI models, machine-learning pipelines and specialised analytics.
Security	Role- and permission-based access control provided by the platform.	Fine-grained access control, specific compliance requirements and enterprise security needs beyond platform features.
Scalability	Suitable where the platform handles the expected users and data volumes.	High data volumes, large user numbers and demanding performance requirements.
Custom functionality	Functionality available as platform features.	Functionality that the platform does not provide.

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Hybrid Approach

Organisations can combine low-code development with pro-code extensions. Low-code is used to develop standard application functionality quickly, while custom code, APIs, integrations or specialised processing are used for requirements that exceed the built-in capabilities of the platform. The structure consists of three layers:

Low-Code Application → Pro-Code Extensions → Enterprise Systems

Users such as members, front-desk staff, trainers, branch managers and administrators access the system at the top, and the three layers are described below.

Layer	Role
Layer 1 – Low-Code Application	Provides rapid development for standard application needs: user interface (web / mobile), forms and reports, workflows, business process automation and standard data management.

Layer	Role
Layer 2 – Pro-Code Extensions	Adds custom logic and specialised capabilities: custom functions, advanced business logic, custom APIs, external integrations, AI / machine-learning services and specialised processing.
Layer 3 – Enterprise Systems	Core systems that provide data, services and infrastructure: CRM, ERP, payment systems, access-control and inventory systems, external databases and analytics platforms.

The reasons for a hybrid approach are faster application development, flexible customisation, integration with existing systems, support for complex business logic and the ability to extend beyond platform limitations. Information flows in both directions between the application, its extensions and the enterprise systems.

When Pro-Code Extension May Become Necessary

- **Complex business logic:** when business rules and processing cannot be represented using standard workflows and rules.
- **Specialized integrations:** when the application must connect to legacy, ERP, access-control or other systems for which suitable connectors are not available.
- **Custom APIs:** when internal services or interfaces have to be exposed or consumed in a way that the platform does not support directly.
- **Advanced AI/ML:** when intelligent features require custom models or machine-learning pipelines.
- **High-performance processing:** when large batches of data or real-time processing exceed what the platform can handle efficiently.
- **Specialized user interfaces:** when the required user experience goes beyond standard components.
- **Complex enterprise data processing:** when large datasets and complex relationships require advanced data handling.
- **Requirements beyond platform capabilities:** when any needed functionality is simply not offered by the selected platform.

Case Study Analysis

For the Enterprise Gym Membership Management System, a low-code platform can be used effectively to develop the standard parts of the system rapidly: forms for membership registration, member and plan details, reports on attendance and membership history, workflows for request processing and approval, notifications, and basic dashboards. These features correspond to the capabilities that low-code platforms are designed to provide.

As the organisation grows, the requirements become more demanding. A large number of members, branches and attendance records raises performance and data-management concerns; integration with payment, CRM, inventory and access-control systems raises integration concerns; differing access needs and the handling of member data raise security and governance concerns; and advanced features such as intelligent analysis may need external services. In such cases, extensions, integrations or custom development may be needed in addition to the low-code application. Low-code is therefore useful for rapidly developing standard business applications, whereas increasingly complex enterprise requirements may call for a hybrid approach, and the choice should be based on the requirements of the application.

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Result

The case study demonstrated the major limitations that can arise when low-code platforms are applied to complex enterprise requirements, namely performance and scalability, complex business logic, system integration, customisation, security and governance, AI and advanced technology, vendor or platform dependency, and data management. It also showed how a hybrid low-code/pro-code approach can address requirements beyond standard low-code capabilities.

Conclusion

Low-code platforms offer speed and simplicity for standard business applications, but their limitations become more significant as enterprise complexity increases. For an application such as the Enterprise Gym Membership Management System, standard functionality can be built quickly using low-code, while demanding requirements in logic, integration, security, scale and advanced technology may need pro-code extensions. It is therefore important to understand the limitations of a platform before selecting a development approach, so that the chosen approach matches the requirements of the enterprise application.

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